Cover letter (draft, not sent)

Date: _____

To: The Editor-in-Chief, International Journal of Forecasting

Dear Editor,

I submit the manuscript “Typed or pooled? Festival covariates in foundation and local forecasting models: unstable orderings, matched controls and a combination hedge” for consideration as a research article.

Forecasters who add holiday or festival indicators must choose whether each event gets its own channel or shares one with other events. Time-series foundation models make this choice more consequential, because the forecaster controls the covariate channels but does not re-estimate the model. The question is therefore practical for readers who use these models with calendar information. The manuscript compares typed and pooled festival indicators for two pinned foundation models and four local specifications on daily electricity in three Indian states, with matched calendar, zero-channel and weekday-placebo controls, a source-driven correction of a festival date, and a separately registered replication on New York City transit ridership.

The main findings are:

- the better representation changes between event years, models and data sources, and with 10 event clusters no ordering can be confirmed by cluster-level tests;
- for the local specifications, daily adaptations of Ziel’s holiday-as-Sunday and replacing designs improve on a calendar baseline in India, as additive flags do, while in NYC event windows the holiday-as-Sunday design is worse in every cell;
- choosing the previous year’s better representation did no better than a random pick, and an equal-weight average of the typed and pooled forecasts had the smallest worst-case regret in both sources, though not a clearly better typical error.

The study is retrospective and limited to two Indian event years and two NYC observances; the manuscript states these limits and does not claim a general ranking of models or representations. Code, protocols, forecasts, failed attempts and audits are in the public repository https://github.com/Binay-verma/tsaf_project [author: push all work before sending]. The reuse terms of the Indian source compilation are still being confirmed with its curator, as described in the data availability statement.

[Author to confirm before sending:] This manuscript has not been published, is not under consideration elsewhere, and has not been posted as a preprint [or: give the preprint link]. Competing interests: _____. Funding: _____.

Possible reviewers (optional, author to decide): _____.

Yours sincerely,

Binay Verma Affiliation: _____ Email: _____